Poetry Toolkit

Cambridge IGCSE Literature in English 0475 · Paper 1, poetry question · Use this with the booklet for each set poem

1 How the poetry question works

- Paper 1 is **poetry and prose**: you answer one question on your poetry set texts and one on your prose text. That gives you about **45 minutes** for the poetry answer.
- Each poetry question is on **one named poem**, and the poem is printed in the paper (check this with your teacher). So you don't need to memorise poems word for word — you need to know each one well enough to analyse it confidently straight away.
- You usually get a choice of two poems from your group.

> *Typical question wording*
> "How does the poet **vividly** convey …?" · "In what ways does the poet make … so **moving**?" · "Explore how the poet creates a **powerful** sense of …" · "How does the poet's writing make … so **memorable**?"
> The word in bold is the heart of the question. Every paragraph must say how the writing makes it vivid / moving / powerful / memorable.

What the examiner rewards (assessment objectives, in plain words)

AO	What it means for you
AO1 Knowledge	You know the poem and back up every point with short quotations.
AO2 Understanding	You go beyond what happens to the **ideas and attitudes** underneath — what the poem is really saying.
AO3 Writer's methods	**How** language, structure and form create meaning and effects. This is the core of a poetry answer.
AO4 Personal response	Your own informed judgement: what you find powerful and why, including other possible readings.

Higher marks go to answers that are detailed, sensitive and sustained all the way through. Lower marks go to answers that retell the poem or just spot features.

2 The 45-minute method

Time	Do this
3 min	**Read the question.** Underline the focus (what it asks about) and the key word (vividly, movingly…).
7 min	**Read the poem twice.** First for meaning: who is speaking, to whom, what situation, how it changes from start to end. Second with a pen: mark 6–8 moments that answer the question.
3 min	**Plan** 3–4 points. Following the poem from beginning to end is the easiest way to stay organised and to make sure you reach the ending.
30 min	**Write:** a 2–3 sentence intro (what the poem is about + your direct answer to the question), 3–4 analytical paragraphs, then a short conclusion with your personal response.
2 min	**Check** that every paragraph uses the question's key word or idea.

Paragraph formula: What → How → Why

WHAT	A point that answers the question (not "in stanza 2…").
HOW	A short quotation (1–6 words) built into your sentence, and the method used.
WHY	The effect. Zoom in on one word — its connotations — then zoom out to the bigger meaning. Offer another reading if you can.
LINK	Tie it back to the question's key word.

Model paragraph

Question: How does Shakespeare make his praise of the beloved so memorable in Sonnet 18?

WHAT Shakespeare makes his praise memorable by suggesting that even a perfect summer falls short of the beloved. **HOW** The opening rhetorical question, 'Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?', sets up a conventional compliment, but the speaker immediately turns it around: the beloved is 'more lovely and more temperate'. **WHY** The word 'temperate' suggests calm and balance, which summer lacks: its 'Rough winds do shake the darling buds of May'. The harsh verb 'shake' threatens the tender, affectionate 'darling buds', so summer seems to damage the very beauty it is famous for. **LINK** By overturning the expected comparison, Shakespeare makes his praise feel original and striking: the beloved is not just like the best thing in nature, but better than it.

3 Techniques — and what to say about them

Naming a technique earns nothing on its own. The last column is what turns it into marks.

Language and imagery

Technique	What it is	Example	What to say about it
Imagery	Words that create a picture or appeal to the senses	*the cold blue light of morning*	What mood does the picture create? Which sense, and why that one?
Simile	Comparison using *like* or *as*	*her voice like broken glass*	Which qualities carry over? (sharp, painful, fragile)
Metaphor	Saying something *is* something else	*the city is a cage*	More forceful than a simile — what does the comparison reveal? (trapped, controlled)
Extended metaphor	One metaphor developed over several lines or the whole poem	*love as a long journey*	Shows how the idea dominates the speaker's thinking; track how it changes.
Personification	Giving human qualities to something non-human	*the wind howled its grief*	Makes nature/objects seem alive, often mirroring the speaker's feelings.
Pathetic fallacy	Weather or setting reflecting emotion	*rain wept on the empty street*	The world seems to share the mood — intensifies it.
Symbol	An object standing for an idea	*a locked door*	What idea does it stand for here? (rejection, loss, secrecy)
Semantic field	A group of words from one topic	*battle, wounds, surrender — in a love poem*	Shows what the speaker associates with the subject (love = conflict).
Connotations	Ideas a word suggests beyond its literal meaning	*home → safety, warmth*	The best way to "zoom in": pick one word and unpack it.
Juxtaposition	Two contrasting things placed close together	*children laughing beside a grave*	Highlights the contrast; often creates shock or irony.
Oxymoron	Two opposite words together	*sweet sorrow*	Shows conflicted, mixed feelings.
Paradox	A statement that seems contradictory but holds a truth	*the more I own, the less I have*	Makes the reader stop and think about a deeper idea.
Hyperbole	Deliberate exaggeration	*I've waited a thousand years*	Shows the intensity of feeling — or mocks, if used ironically.
Irony	Gap between what's said and what's meant, or between expectation and reality	*"What a lovely day" in a storm*	Reveals bitterness, criticism or humour.
Direct address / "you"	Speaking straight to someone	*You never asked me why*	Intimate, accusing or involving the reader — which one here?

Technique	What it is	Example	What to say about it
Apostrophe	Addressing someone absent or dead, or an object/idea	*O river, carry me home*	Shows longing or desperation; the listener can't answer.
Rhetorical question	A question not expecting an answer	*What else could I have done?*	Shows doubt, anger or guilt; makes the reader reflect.
Imperative	A command	*Remember me.*	Urgency, authority or desperation.
Tone	The attitude of the voice	*bitter, tender, nostalgic*	Never just name it — say which words create it, and where it shifts.
Diction / register	Word choice; how formal or casual	*slang vs. formal, old-fashioned words*	What does the voice's style tell us about the speaker?

Sound

Technique	What it is	Example	What to say about it
Alliteration	Same consonant sound starting nearby words	*cold, cruel coast*	Say **which** sound and its effect: hard 'c/k' sounds harsh; soft 'f/l' gentle.
Sibilance	Repeated 's' / 'sh' sounds	*the sea's soft sighing*	Soothing and whispering — or hissing and sinister. Which one here?
Plosives	Repeated p, b, t, d, k, g	*bombs burst*	Explosive, violent or angry.
Assonance	Repeated vowel sounds	*the low moan of the old road*	Long vowels slow the line — mournful, heavy.
Onomatopoeia	A word that sounds like its meaning	*crack, hiss, murmur*	Makes the moment vivid — you hear it.
Rhyme scheme	Pattern of end rhymes (ABAB…)	—	Regular rhyme: order, control, song-like. Broken rhyme: disorder. Half-rhyme (soul/all): something slightly wrong or unresolved.
Rhythm / metre	Pattern of stressed syllables	*iambic pentameter: da-DUM × 5*	Regular rhythm can feel like a heartbeat, a march or a chant. A break in the rhythm draws attention to that moment.
Repetition / anaphora / refrain	Repeated words; repeated line openings; a repeated line	*Again I … / Again I …*	Emphasis, obsession, chant-like build-up.
Listing, asyndeton, polysyndeton	Lists; no "and"s; lots of "and"s	*and rain and mud and cold*	Overwhelming, breathless, piling up.

Structure

Technique	What it is	Example	What to say about it
Caesura	A pause in the middle of a line (punctuation)	*I called. No answer.*	Hesitation, shock, a break in thought; emphasises the words either side.
Enjambment	A sentence running over the end of a line	—	Speed, overflowing emotion, thoughts that can't be contained; puts weight on the first word of the next line.
End-stopped line	A line ending with punctuation	—	Control, finality, calm.
Stanzas	The "paragraphs" of a poem	—	Regular stanzas: order. Irregular: chaos. What changes from one stanza to the next?
Volta	A turning point in argument or tone	*But… / Yet…*	A change of perspective — always comment on it.
Cyclical structure	Ending where it began	—	Trapped, nothing has changed — or a sense of completeness.

Technique	What it is	Example	What to say about it
Short line / single-line stanza	A line that stands apart	—	Isolation, emphasis, a moment of shock.
Shifts	Changes in tense, pronoun or tone	*past → present; "I" → "we"*	Shows the speaker's understanding or feeling changing.
Title, opening, ending	—	—	Always comment on the ending: it is where the poem makes its final point.

Form

Form	What it is	Clue	What to say about it
Sonnet	14 lines, traditionally about love. Shakespearean: 3 quatrains + a rhyming couplet. Petrarchan: 8 lines + 6, turning at line 9.	*14 lines*	Is the poet using the love form straight, or for a different subject (grief, war)? Where is the volta?
Dramatic monologue	A character (not the poet) speaks to a silent listener	*"you" who never replies*	The speaker often reveals more about themselves than they intend.
Free verse	No regular rhyme or metre	—	Natural speech, freedom — or unpredictability and disorder.
Ballad	Tells a story in regular, song-like stanzas	*4-line stanzas, rhyme*	Simple, memorable — can make a tragic story feel like a folk tale.
Elegy	A poem mourning someone who has died	—	Grief, remembrance; does it move towards comfort?
Ode	A poem of praise addressed to something	*"To…"*	Admiration, celebration — is it sincere?
Lyric	A short poem of personal feeling	—	Intimate, emotional.
Blank verse	Unrhymed iambic pentameter	—	Serious and dignified, but close to natural speech.

4 Phrase bank

Instead of "shows"
suggests · implies · conveys · evokes · reveals · emphasises · highlights · reinforces · intensifies · foreshadows · mirrors · contrasts with · undermines · creates a sense of

Zooming in
"The word 'X' is especially powerful because…"
"Its connotations of … suggest…"
"The harsh / gentle sound of … mirrors…"

Words for tone

Positive
tender · affectionate · reverent · joyful · celebratory · awed · hopeful · nostalgic · wistful

Negative
bitter · resentful · despairing · mournful · melancholic · sombre · menacing · sinister · contemptuous · sardonic

Other
reflective · detached · ironic · ambivalent · playful · defiant · urgent · conversational · intimate · matter-of-fact

Other readings (AO4)
"Perhaps…" · "This could also suggest…" · "A darker reading is that…" · "On the surface …, but underneath …"

Personal response (AO4)
"What I find most striking is…" · "The final image is particularly moving because…" · "The poem leaves the reader feeling…"

5 Mistakes that cost marks

Watch out

- **Feature spotting:** “There is alliteration in line 3.” Only name a technique if you explain its effect.
- **Retelling the poem** instead of explaining *how* the writing works.
- **Forgetting the question’s key word** (vividly, movingly…).
- **Empty effects:** “makes the reader want to read on”, “makes it flow”, “makes the reader think”. Say exactly what the reader feels or understands.
- **Long quotations.** Quote 1–6 words and build them into your sentence.
- **“The poet says…”** Say “the speaker” unless the poem is clearly about the poet’s own life.
- **Running out of time before the ending.** The ending usually holds the poem’s main point.
- **Context bolted on** that doesn’t help answer the question.

Blank poem sheet (photocopy one per poem)

Poem Poet

In one sentence: what is it about?

Speaker · who to · situation

How it moves: start → middle → end (where's the turn?)

Tone(s)

Themes

Key quotations

Quote (1–6 words)	Method	Effect — zoom in on a word

Form and structure

Likely question — "How does the poet vividly / movingly …?"